

Final Teaching Project

Dennis Gahm

TH5314-30: Theology 4: Ecclesiology and Eschatology

Professor: Chris Hippe

Introduction

This report will talk about my experience teaching two lessons to my friend Kenneth. The lessons were about Church Purity and Church Government. He had a lot to talk about and had good questions. I asked lots of open-ended questions, and he said he was enlightened by two things: by what the Invisible Church is, and what the True Church is.

The topic of Church is variegated and has a spiritual component, but also a practical component. Is the intersection of these two components that make the topic of church realistic and interesting.

The topic of Church Purity and Church Government were discussed with Ken and myself.

Church Purity

1. I taught Kenneth

2. I taught him that the invisible church is the true church. He was very curious about what the True Church is - as if some churches could be false. But I told him that every church has at least some bit of falsity. He loved to hear about the True Church and how it is spiritual yet truly on earth. He enjoyed learning how the true church will have a good combination and balance of worship, fellowship, and evangelism.

3. He also asked me, "What is the invisible Church and what is the True Church?"

4. For the Invisible Church, I told him that he was right in saying that the church is by the authority of Christ and that the church is the body of Christ. This is totally true for the invisible church. I would like to add that even though we are technically biological beings on this earth, our physical presence is still considered invisible because we are spirits existing not in a building.

Thus, I told Kenneth that the Visible Church is the building of a Church, not just the believers. He was surprised to hear that there are two different churches, and that the church that we go to may not be the real church.

This leads to the next topic that if it is a visible church, is it the true church. I told him that the Invisible Church is the True Church, and that the Visible Church is doing its best to be the earthly church for the Invisible Church.

If I had to choose between the Invisible Church and the Visible Church, which one is the True Church, I would say the Invisible Church is the True Church.

And he was surprised because it made him understand that every Visible Church may not be completely conformed to the Invisible Church. He knows this - he encountered many False Churches that are Visible, and I told him that every True Church has a purity level, and that no True Church is 100% Pure. Every Church will have some flaws - that is the nature of Church on Earth.

5. Some applications I gave were that every church he visits will have some flaws, and that it is okay to criticize the church and its pastor - but that we must do so lovingly and with the Word of God.

He realized that he always has 15% of himself criticizing the church service for something he didn't agree with - whether it be too much worldliness in the sermon, or something unbiblical.

Overall, I thought that Kenneth was a great student, and we had a great conversation. We shared fellowship together and got to share our thoughts and hearts with each other.

Kenneth shared his personal life by sharing information about his family and his church experiences. I also got to share with him some of my struggles, and how Church helped me overcome many of my struggles.

It was a blessing to see Kenneth enjoying the conversation, and to see him learning more about Church and theology.

I really hope that he can continue to grow as a theologian and be a leader in the church.

I thought it was important to talk about the True Church, that the Church needs to do worship, evangelism, and fellowship.

It was so important to us that we each get enough fellowship in our lives.

Also, Kenneth found it heart-warming that worship and music can be simple and not complicated - simply touching our hearts and minds, and allowing us to feel the blessedness and peace of God.

Church Government

1. I taught Kenneth

2. We also talked about Church Government, and the biggest issue was whether women can be pastors. We both agreed that women can lead in some fashion, but not as lead pastors. He found the idea of apostleship to be interesting.

3. Kenneth asked me, “Can the church tell you how to vote?” He was very invested in this question, and had a personal story that got him involved personally in the answer. He really truly believed that the church does not have the authority to tell someone how to vote. He was emphatic about it.

4. I told him that the Bible says that homosexuality is against nature and is a sin. Therefore, it wouldn’t be completely wrong for the church to tell its members to vote against gay marriage.

He was surprised to some degree, and convinced that this was a good answer because I used a Bible verse to back it up. He especially wanted me to answer his question with a Bible verse.

I had a more hypothetical answer to back it up. I said, “If we were living during the time of Nero, and Nero wanted to burn Christians and make that a government law, wouldn’t the church order its members to vote against that law?”

He nodded his head, and realized that is a correct answer.

5. Kenneth told me that in his life, he would attend churches that would have women preaching. And when he would hear them preach, he would always be thinking in his head, “Ah, this is not good - a woman should not be preaching.”

And I told him that I agree with him to some degree.

One thing that I did not tell him exactly, but that I believe is that women may be able to preach, as there are prophetesses in the Bible.

However, we both agreed that women should not be lead pastors.

I believe that this was my weak lesson of the two, because although I am pumped up about teaching about church government, it is not my favorite topic actually because it is the least spiritual.

You see, church government is how to run the church in an organized fashion in a systematic and worldly way.

A congregational church vs a presbyterian church is not a debate that the Bible would focus on - this is not a spiritual issue and is a side topic.

The more important matter is to be a husband of one wife and to not be a lover of money.

What I’m trying to say, is that the spiritual matters are more important than the physical, and earthly matters.

Unfortunately, I feel as of this moment that church government is a worldly topic.

However, the topic of, “Who is an Apostle and what is the definition of an Apostle,” was a very fascinating topic for both me and Kenneth.

I proudly told Kenneth that Grudem said that there are more apostles than 12 because of a certain verse in the Book of Acts.

Also, the topic of women pastoring was a topic that was the most focused on by Kenneth. He was passionate about women not pastoring.

I told him that the Biblical verse that makes me think that women should not pastor is when Apostle Paul talks about how the female was the one deceived by the serpent, and thus, should not exercise authority over the man.

I think this is a clear argument against women pastoring, and is not culturally based, because it is based on Genesis.

You see, I told him some of my Faith Seminary professors’ viewpoints that women can pastor in some sense. One of the Calvin Theological Seminary professors that I watched for video lectures said that women were not educated during that time, and because they were not educated they should not pastor. Therefore, if they are educated, today, they can pastor.

Also, women were not supposed to oust the authority from man or the pastor in Corinthians, but the professor said that this meant something like a violent takeover of leadership of the church, rather than simply being appointed as pastor.

Therefore, I showed Kenneth a different viewpoint, as my professor did, and we saw the other side of the argument; however, we were both convinced that women should not lead as a pastor.